

Behind the scenes

Richard Dymond

Who could forget Shamsky, Sherry, Cohen and Kauff?



Dymond

Ron Blomberg, Art Shamsky ... then the next two names that shot into my head were Barry Katz and Marc Mandell.

Katz lived up the street from me when I was growing up. He was the kid whose mother made him go out and play because his cheeks had no color. We stuck him in right field.

Mandell was a friend whose entire baseball career centered on a Little League game when he was about 10 and the resulting tiny newspaper clipping, which erroneously credited him with a double. Actually, he had gone zero-for-four.

Thus, I was amazed by the response to the All-Jewish team. The ballots rolled in. There have been many more Jewish major league players than I realized.

How could I have forgotten Norm Miller, the injury-prone Atlanta Brave in the early 1970s, who was finally released by the Dodgers in 1975?

How about Richie Scheinblum? After a great minor league career, in which Scheinblum hit 388 with 25 homers for Denver, he hit only 13 major league homers in eight years and finished up in Japan.

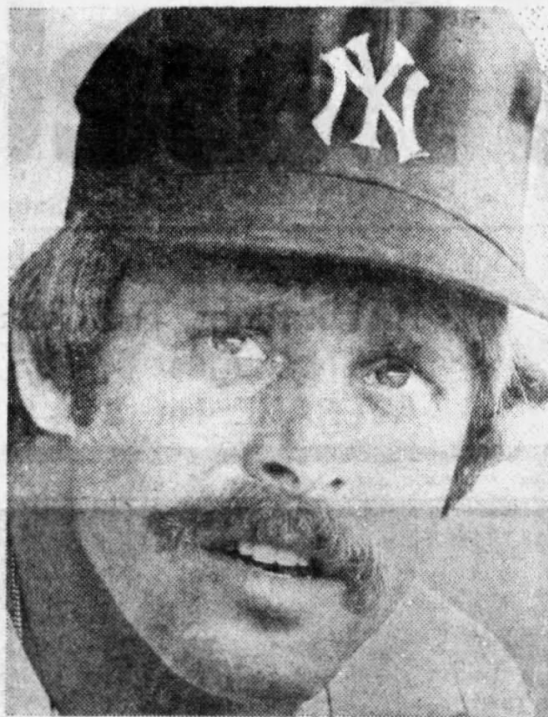
Wait, I'm not finished.

How could I forget Ken Holtzman, who bounced around during the '70s? How about the old-timers, such as Buddy Myer, Joe Ginsberg, Al (Flip) Rosen, Andy Cohen, Larry and Norm Sherry and Benny Kauff?

Finally, I realized, getting the ballots or counting the votes wasn't to be the big problem with this project. The problem was, I was getting some very suspicious names. Were some of these guys really Jewish?

Is Elliott Maddox of the Mets a convert? Is Jim Palmer really Jewish? How about catcher Johnny Kling? What about Rod Carew, the famous Panamanian?

About then, I ran into Palm Island's Marshall Berkson, a business investor whose hobby is col-



Ron Blomberg makes all-star team

lecting Jewish sports memorabilia. Berkson let me borrow 17 issues of the now defunct Jewish Sports Review, as esoteric a sports treasure as there is. I was amazed at the amount of information therein.

JSR solved my problems. It gave me all the facts about the half- and near-Jews. It seems if you were a Jewish baseball player, or maybe had once munched a bagel and lox in Wolfie's during spring training, JSR had a bead on you.

JSR confirmed Maddox' conversion. It also solved the Palmer mystery. Palmer is the son of a New York garment manufacturer named Weiser, who was Jewish. After Weiser's death, Jim's mother married Max Palmer, a Hollywood stunt man. Jim took the last name Palmer and did not practice Judaism.

"I am not Jewish, I don't practice," Palmer told a JSR reporter, who brought the disappointing news back to his anxious readers.

While Palmer can be removed from the list of potential all-stars, Carew belongs. The Angels' infielder told a JSR interviewer that he converted to Judaism when his first child was borne him by his Jewish wife in 1974.

As for Kling, who received the most votes in the catcher category, his 100-year-old wife reported to JSR that he was not a Jew. Strike Kling.

Finally, we compiled our team (as you can see on page 11) and everything worked out fine. I can only wonder how those guys who put out the JSR bear not having it around anymore. I wanted to call them up, boasting that Steve Stone can be the first Jewish pitcher since Holtzman in 1973 to win 20 games in one year.

But they probably would have known that.